

Why and How to Become an Open Source Contributor



Open source is often associated with coding, giving the impression it's meant only for computer geeks. But anybody can become an open source contributor — even if they haven't written a line of code their entire life. Sounds interesting? Then read on...

The beginning of the New Year calls for bringing about a change in your life. It could be learning a new skill, becoming healthier, performing your best at work or studies, or anything fruitful that will help you develop as a person. And it would be great if that change could benefit others too. So here's an interesting proposition — become an open source contributor.

But why?

To which, I say why not? After all, it is exciting and will help you achieve

your objectives. And most importantly, you don't need to be an expert in coding. You can contribute without possessing any prior coding experience.

Interested? Let's do it. But first, a bit of the basics.

The formal definition of open source software goes like this: Open source software is software whose *source code* is released under a *licence* that grants anyone the right to inspect, modify and distribute it for any purpose. The two important things to

note in this definition are source code and licence.

Releasing a source code for free doesn't hinder you from selling the result of your creation. It's possible to earn money based on open source software and make a living out of it. Companies, including GitHub and MongoDB, to name a few, are doing just that. Nevertheless, there's a lot more to simply giving away all your software for free.

There's also a difference between free software (not as in free beer) and open source software. While free